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CUET UG

Political Science

Regional Aspiration and Conflicts

Official Syllabus · Politics in India Since Independence · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Politics in India Since Independence)	Skills the questions test
Indian Federal Model	Rise of regional parties — democratic accommodation of regional diversity versus cultural assimilation.	Contrasting India's pluralist federalism with European nation-state models; understanding Article 371 and autonomous tribal councils.
The Kashmir Situation	The Kashmir situation — roots of conflict, Article 370, Sheikh Abdullah's politics, and the post-1987 militancy.	Tracing the 1947 accession, 1953 arrest, 1974 Indira-Sheikh Accord, and the 1989 cross-border insurgency.
The Punjab Crisis	Punjab crisis and the anti-Sikh riots of 1984 — Anandpur Sahib Resolution, Operation Blue Star, and the Longowal Accord.	Chronologising the Punjabi Suba movement, Bhindranwale's militancy, the June 1984 military action, and the July 1985 Punjab Accord.
The North-East & Regional Parties	Challenges and responses in the North East — Mizo insurgency, Assam movement against outsiders, and the rise of regional parties.	Recalling the Mizo Accord (Laldenga), the Assam Accord (24 March 1971 cutoff date), and the emergence of AGP and TDP.

EXAM PATTERN

CUET UG pattern (NTA official information bulletin and syllabus, 2026 cycle — the current 2027 baseline): each subject paper carries **50 compulsory questions** in **60 minutes**, with +5 for every correct answer and −1 for every incorrect answer. This chapter tests exact peace accords (Rajiv Gandhi era: Punjab, Assam, Mizo), cutoff dates, rebel leaders, special constitutional articles, and the core philosophy of democratic accommodation.

The Indian Approach: Accommodation over Assimilation

When India gained freedom, European political thinkers predicted that a country with hundreds of languages, distinct tribal groups, and diverse religions would inevitably splinter into hostile warring states. India disproved this by adopting an innovative model of nation-building.

- **Unity through Diversity — The Core Philosophy:**
  - **Rejecting the melting-pot model:** Unlike Western nation-states that sought cultural and linguistic assimilation ("one language, one nation"), India recognized that cultural diversity is permanent and valuable.
  - **Regionalism is not anti-national:** In Indian democracy, expressing regional, linguistic, or cultural pride is considered a natural and legitimate part of federal politics, not treason.
  - **Dual identity accepted:** An Indian citizen can proudly be a Tamil, a Bengali, a Mizo, or a Punjabi, while simultaneously being a loyal Indian patriot.
  - **Democratic negotiation:** When regional grievances boil over into conflict, the Indian state responds not through permanent military suppression, but through political dialogue, constitutional flexibility, and power-sharing peace accords.
- **Asymmetrical Federalism:**
  - The Constitution does not treat all states identically; it provides tailor-made constitutional protections:
    - **Article 370 (now abrogated):** Granted special internal autonomy to Jammu and Kashmir.
    - **Article 371 (A to J):** Special provisions for Nagaland, Mizoram, Assam, Manipur, Andhra Pradesh, and Karnataka to safeguard customary laws and indigenous land rights.
    - **Fifth and Sixth Schedules:** Autonomous District Councils that empower tribal communities to govern their own lands, forests, and customs.

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THE MOSAIC VERSUS THE PUREE

Think of nation-building in two ways. Assimilation is like throwing different vegetables into a blender and making a puree: every unique flavour is destroyed to create a single uniform soup. Accommodation is like an intricate mosaic: thousands of distinct, colourful glass tiles are placed side by side to construct a single grand picture. India is a constitutional mosaic: each tile keeps its brilliant colour, and together they form the union.

Jammu and Kashmir: The Politics of Autonomy & Insurgency

Jammu and Kashmir is not merely a border dispute between India and Pakistan; it represents a complex clash of regional aspirations, external interference, and constitutional experiments.

- **The Three Regional Zones:**
  - **Kashmir Valley:** Predominantly Kashmiri-speaking and Muslim, with a small Kashmiri Pandit minority.

- **Jammu:** Mixed population of Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs; primarily plains and foothills; favoured closer integration with India.
- **Ladakh:** High-altitude mountainous terrain; Buddhist and Muslim population; demanded autonomy from Valley-dominated politics.

- **Roots of the Dispute (1947–1953):**
  - **Maharaja Hari Singh's hesitation:** In August 1947, the Hindu ruler of Muslim-majority J&K dreamed of staying independent.
  - **The Pakistani invasion (October 1947):** Pakistan sent armed Pathan tribal raiders backed by its military. Facing total collapse, Hari Singh signed the **Instrument of Accession** with India on 26 October 1947.
  - **The special deal:** The Accession was accepted on condition that once peace was restored, the will of the people would be ascertained. India granted J&K special internal autonomy under **Article 370**.
  - **Sheikh Abdullah's era:** Popular leader **Sheikh Abdullah** of the National Conference became Prime Minister of J&K. He initiated sweeping land reforms abolishing landlordism without compensation.
  - **The 1953 Rift:** Differences grew over J&K's constitutional status. In August 1953, the Central government dismissed Sheikh Abdullah and kept him in detention for over a decade.
- **The Accord and the Eruption of Insurgency:**
  - **1974 Indira-Sheikh Accord:** After prolonged talks, Indira Gandhi and Sheikh Abdullah signed a peace pact. Sheikh dropped the plebiscite demand and returned as Chief Minister of J&K in 1975.
  - **Farooq Abdullah's succession:** After Sheikh's death in 1982, his son **Farooq Abdullah** took over, but was dismissed by the Centre in 1984, breeding popular resentment.
  - **The 1987 Election Trigger:** In the March 1987 Assembly elections, the National Conference-Congress alliance faced a massive challenge from the **Muslim United Front (MUF)**. The elections were widely perceived as rigged.
  - **The 1989 Armed Insurgency:** Frustrated youth lost faith in democratic elections, crossed the Line of Control into Pakistan for weapons training, and returned to launch a violent armed insurgency in 1989.
  - **Human cost:** Violence led to the tragic exodus of almost the entire Kashmiri Pandit community from the Valley in 1990, followed by decades of counter-insurgency and cross-border terrorism.

The Punjab Crisis: From Grievance to Peace

The crisis in Punjab during the 1980s was one of the most violent challenges to Indian nation-building, but it ultimately ended in democratic reconciliation.

- **The Roots — Linguistic Suba to Anandpur Resolution:**
  - **The Punjabi Suba demand:** The **Shiromani Akali Dal** campaigned for a Punjabi-speaking state. In 1966, the central government reorganized Punjab, carving out Hindi-speaking **Haryana** and hilly **Himachal Pradesh**.

- **The Anandpur Sahib Resolution (1973):** Akali Dal passed a historic resolution demanding greater provincial autonomy, limiting the Centre's role to defence, foreign affairs, currency, and communications, and seeking the transfer of Chandigarh exclusively to Punjab.
- **The fringe misinterpretation:** While moderate Akalis wanted true federalism, extremist groups began misinterpreting the resolution as a demand for a separate sovereign Sikh nation (**Khalistan**).

- **Radicalisation & Operation Blue Star (1980–1984):**
  - **Rise of Bhindranwale:** Radical preacher **Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale** emerged as the spearhead of armed militancy, preaching religious fundamentalism and targeting political rivals.
  - **Fortification of the Golden Temple:** Militants turned the sacred **Harmandir Sahib** (Golden Temple complex) in Amritsar into an armed fortress with heavy machine guns.
  - **Operation Blue Star (June 1984):** Prime Minister Indira Gandhi ordered the Indian Army to flush out the militants. Tanks and commandos entered the complex. Bhindranwale was killed, but the historic **Akal Takht** suffered heavy structural damage and civilian pilgrims died in crossfire.
  - **The trauma:** The military assault deeply wounded Sikh sentiments across India and abroad, creating profound alienation.
- **The Assassination and 1984 Anti-Sikh Violence:**
  - **31 October 1984:** Prime Minister Indira Gandhi was shot dead outside her residence by two of her Sikh bodyguards, Beant Singh and Satwant Singh.
  - **The Anti-Sikh Riots:** For four days, organized mobs attacked Sikh neighbourhoods in Delhi, Kanpur, Bokaro, and other towns. Over **2,700 Sikhs were massacred** in the national capital alone.
  - **State failure:** The police stood by passively or colluded with rioters. It took decades of commission inquiries (notably the **Justice Nanavati Commission**) to indict ruling party leaders. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh issued a formal state apology in Parliament in 2005.
- **The Rajiv-Longowal Accord (July 1985):**
  - New Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi reached out to moderate Akali Dal President **Sant Harchand Singh Longowal**.
  - **Key terms of the Punjab Accord:**
    - Chandigarh to be transferred to Punjab.
    - A judicial commission to resolve the boundary dispute between Punjab and Haryana.
    - A tribunal to adjudicate the sharing of Ravi-Beas river waters.
    - Withdrawal of the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA) once normalcy returned.
  - **The martyrdom of Longowal:** Within a month of signing, Longowal was assassinated by extremists.

- **Return to peace:** Tough counter-terrorism policing combined with the restoration of democratic elections in 1992 and 1997 (when the Akali Dal-BJP alliance won) finally brought permanent peace to Punjab.

Event / Document	Year	Core Significance in Punjab Politics
Creation of Punjab State	1966	Bifurcated old Punjab into Punjabi-speaking Punjab and Hindi-speaking Haryana.
Anandpur Sahib Resolution	1973	Demanded greater state autonomy and federal restructuring within India.
Operation Blue Star	June 1984	Military operation to flush out militants from the Golden Temple complex, Amritsar.
Rajiv-Longowal Accord	July 1985	Historic peace agreement signed between Rajiv Gandhi and Harchand Singh Longowal.

The North-East: Autonomy, Secession, and Accords

The North-Eastern region comprises the **"Seven Sisters"** (Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Nagaland, Tripura, Arunachal Pradesh) and Sikkim. Connected to mainland India by the fragile 22-kilometre **Siliguri Corridor** ("Chicken's Neck"), it witnessed three distinct types of regional movements.

- **1. Demands for Autonomy within the Union:**
  - At Independence, the entire region (except Manipur and Tripura princely states) was part of a giant composite state of Assam.
  - Non-Assamese hill tribes resented the imposition of the Assamese language.
  - The Centre reorganized the region along tribal identities: **Nagaland (1963)**, **Meghalaya, Manipur, and Tripura (1972)**, and **Mizoram and Arunachal Pradesh (1987)**.
- **2. Secessionist Movements: Mizoram and Nagaland:**
  - **The Mizo Insurgency & Laldenga:**
    - **The origin:** In 1959, the Mizo Hills suffered the devastating **Mautam** (bamboo flowering famine). The Assam government handled relief with indifference, sparking bitter resentment.
    - **The MNF: Laldenga** formed the **Mizo National Front (MNF)**. In March 1966, the MNF declared independence and launched an armed guerrilla insurrection.
    - **The war:** The Indian military conducted counter-insurgency operations, including controversial air strikes on Aizawl in 1966 and village regroupings.

- **The Mizo Peace Accord (1986):** After 20 years of jungle warfare, Rajiv Gandhi and Laldenga signed a historic peace accord. Mizoram was granted full statehood with special constitutional safeguards under Article 371G.
- **Rehabilitation:** MNF rebels laid down arms; Laldenga was sworn in as Chief Minister. Today, Mizoram stands as one of the most peaceful and literate states in India.

- **The Naga Movement:**
  - **The pioneer:** Led by **Angami Zapu Phizo**, the **Naga National Council (NNC)** declared independent Nagaland in August 1947, refusing to join the Indian Union.
  - **Statehood in 1963:** India created the state of Nagaland in 1963 to win over moderates, but hardline factions (notably the **NSCN**) continued armed struggle. Prolonged ceasefire talks continue to this day.

- **3. Movements Against "Outsiders": The Assam Movement (1979–1985):**
  - **The grievance:** Massive, unchecked demographic influx of Bengali-speaking migrants from East Pakistan/Bangladesh stoked fears that indigenous Assamese people would be reduced to a minority on their own ancestral soil.
  - **The leadership:** Led by the **All Assam Students Union (AASU)** and the All Assam Gana Sangram Parishad (AAGSP).
  - **The agitation:** Spanned six years (1979–1985) of strikes, oil pipeline blockades, and communal flare-ups (such as the tragic Nellie massacre in 1983).
  - **The Assam Accord (15 August 1985):**
    - Signed on Independence Day 1985 between Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and AASU leaders, notably **Prafulla Kumar Mahanta**.
    - **The Cutoff Date:** Migrants who entered Assam before **1 January 1966** were granted full citizenship. Those entering between **1966 and 24 March 1971** were disfranchised for 10 years.
    - All foreigners who entered Assam illegally on or after **25 March 1971** were to be detected, deleted from electoral rolls, and deported.
  - **Democratic Transition:** AASU leaders formed a regional political party, the **Asom Gana Parishad (AGP)**, and swept to power in the December 1985 state elections, with 31-year-old Prafulla Kumar Mahanta becoming India's youngest Chief Minister.

The Rise of Regional Parties

Since the late 1960s, regional parties have transformed from marginal provincial players into the central architects of national governance.

- **Catalysts for Regional Parties:**
  - Failure of national parties (especially Congress) to accommodate diverse regional cultural, linguistic, and developmental concerns.
  - Centralised High Command culture that dismissed popular state Chief Ministers arbitrarily.
  - Emergence of powerful regional castes and agrarian elites wanting a direct share of state power.

- **Prominent Regional Parties & Their Ideological Planks:**
  - **DMK & AIADMK (Tamil Nadu):** Championed Dravidian identity, social justice, anti-Hindi language protection, and state autonomy.
  - **Shiromani Akali Dal (Punjab):** Voice of Sikh identity, agrarian interests, and federal decentralisation.
  - **Telugu Desam Party (Andhra Pradesh):** Founded in 1982 by film superstar **N.T. Rama Rao (NTR)** on the powerful platform of "Telugu Self-Respect" (**Atma Gauravam**), routing Congress within nine months of formation.
  - **National Conference (J&K) & AGP (Assam):** Born directly out of popular regional autonomy struggles.
- **Impact on Indian Federalism:**
  - Regional parties shattered the era of single-party dominance.
  - In the coalition era (1989–2014), no national party could form a Central government without the alliance support of regional parties (NDA and UPA coalitions).
  - Power shifted decisively from New Delhi to state capitals, deepening Indian democracy.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture

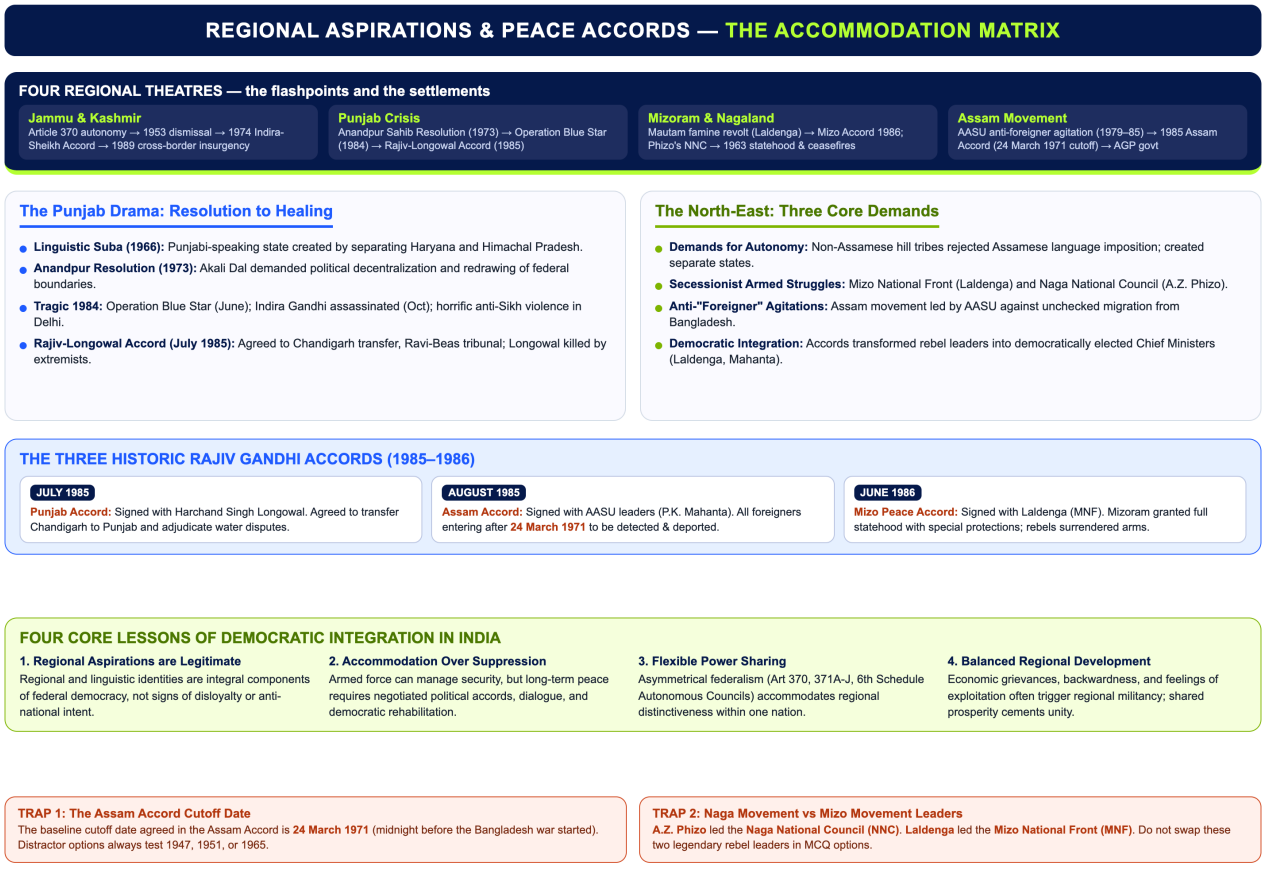


Figure 1: Regional Aspirations & Accommodation Matrix: Comparing the four theatres (Kashmir, Punjab, Mizoram, Assam), the three Rajiv Gandhi peace accords of 1985–86, and the core democratic lessons of Indian federalism.



Figure 2: Complete Chapter Mindmap: The Indian accommodation model, J&K constitutional history, Punjab crisis and 1984 violence, North-East tribal autonomy and secession, and the rise of powerful regional parties.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. In October 1947, who was the Maharaja of the princely state of Jammu and Kashmir who signed the Instrument of Accession with India?

(A) Maharaja Gulab Singh
(B) Maharaja Hari Singh
(C) Sheikh Abdullah
(D) Karan Singh

Q2. In which year did the historic Anandpur Sahib Resolution, demanding greater state autonomy, get passed by the Shiromani Akali Dal?

(A) 1966
(B) 1971
(C) 1973
(D) 1984

Q3. Operation Blue Star, the military assault on the Golden Temple complex in Amritsar, was conducted in which month and year?

(A) June 1984
(B) October 1984
(C) July 1985
(D) January 1986

Q4. The Punjab Accord of July 1985 was signed between Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and which prominent Akali Dal leader?

(A) Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale
(B) Parkash Singh Badal
(C) Harchand Singh Longowal
(D) Gurcharan Singh Tohra

Q5. The Mizo National Front (MNF), which waged a 20-year armed insurgency in the Mizo Hills, was founded and led by:

(A) Angami Zapu Phizo
(B) Laldenga
(C) Prafulla Kumar Mahanta
(D) Bhrigu Kumar Phukan

Q6. Under the historic Assam Accord signed in August 1985, what was the mutually agreed cutoff date for the identification and deportation of illegal foreigners?

(A) 15 August 1947
(B) 26 January 1950
(C) 24 March 1971
(D) 1 January 1980

Q7. Which regional political party was formed in 1985 by student leaders who led the six-year-long anti-foreigner agitation in Assam?

(A) All Assam Students Union
(B) Asom Gana Parishad
(C) Bodo People's Front
(D) United Minorities Front

Q8. The Telugu Desam Party (TDP) was founded in 1982 on the platform of Telugu self-respect (Atma Gauravam) by which popular film icon?

(A) M.G. Ramachandran
(B) N.T. Rama Rao
(C) Chiranjeevi
(D) K. Karunanidhi

Q9. Which state was carved out from composite Assam in 1963 to satisfy the long-standing autonomy demand of the local tribes?

(A) Meghalaya
(B) Nagaland
(C) Mizoram
(D) Manipur

Q10. Following the anti-Sikh violence of 1984, which judicial inquiry commission was appointed in 2000 to submit a comprehensive report on the Delhi massacres?

(A) Sarkaria Commission
(B) Shah Commission
(C) Nanavati Commission
(D) Verma Commission

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. Maharaja Hari Singh was the Hindu ruler of J&K who signed the Instrument of Accession on 26 October 1947 to seek Indian military aid against Pakistani tribal invaders.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. The Anandpur Sahib Resolution was passed by the Akali Dal in 1973, articulating demands for federal restructuring, river water redistribution, and greater provincial autonomy.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q3. Operation Blue Star was conducted by the Indian Army in June 1984 to eliminate armed militants led by Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale from the Golden Temple complex.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q4. Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi signed the historic Memorandum of Settlement (Punjab Accord) in July 1985 with Sant Harchand Singh Longowal, President of the Akali Dal.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. Laldenga founded the Mizo National Front (MNF) following the 1959 Mautam famine and led the armed rebellion before signing the 1986 Mizo Peace Accord to become Chief Minister.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q6. The Assam Accord fixed midnight of 24 March 1971 (the eve of the Bangladesh Liberation War) as the strict cutoff date for identifying and deporting illegal immigrants.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. AASU leaders transformed their student movement into a formal regional political party named Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) in 1985, winning the assembly elections.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. N.T. Rama Rao (NTR), legendary Telugu cinema superstar, formed the Telugu Desam Party in 1982, routing the ruling Congress in Andhra Pradesh within nine months.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. Nagaland was granted full statehood in 1963, becoming the first tribal state carved out from composite Assam to accommodate the Naga movement.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. The Justice G.T. Nanavati Commission of Inquiry was appointed in 2000 by the NDA government to probe the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, indicting several influential figures.

Answer: (C)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q4 option A	Picking the militant leader	Bhindranwale was killed in 1984; Rajiv Gandhi signed the accord with moderate leader Longowal.
Q5 option A	Swapping Naga and Mizo leaders	Phizo led the Naga movement (NNC); Laldenga led the Mizo movement (MNF).
Q6 option A	Using Independence date as cutoff	The Assam Accord cutoff is 24 March 1971 (linked to Bangladesh war refugees).
Q8 option A	Confusing Tamil and Telugu film icons	MGR founded AIADMK in Tamil Nadu; NTR founded TDP in Andhra Pradesh.
Q10 option B	Picking the Emergency commission	The Shah Commission probed the 1975–77 Emergency; the Nanavati Commission probed the 1984 riots.

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